

Northside Home Goods

Acceptable Use Policy (AUP)

Version: 1.0 | **Applies To:** All Employees, Contractors, and Third-Party Users

1. Purpose and Scope

The purpose of this Acceptable Use Policy is to define the acceptable and ethical use of Northside Home Goods' information resources. This policy ensures that our retail operations, customer data, and financial systems remain secure and compliant. This policy applies to all 40 employees, contractors, temporary staff, and any third parties accessing Northside Home Goods' networks, Point-of-Sale (POS) systems, e-commerce platforms, or cloud infrastructure.

2. General Use and Ownership

1. **Corporate Property:** All information systems, email accounts, POS terminals, hardware, and software provided by Northside Home Goods are the sole property of the company.
2. **No Expectation of Privacy:** Northside Home Goods reserves the right to audit, inspect, and monitor all network traffic, email communications, and device activity on corporate resources. Users should have no expectation of privacy when using corporate property.
3. **Incidental Personal Use:** Occasional, incidental personal use of corporate devices (e.g., checking a personal email during a break) is permitted provided it does not interfere with business operations, consume excessive network resources, or violate any prohibitions in this policy.

3. Password and Authentication Standards

Strong authentication is our primary defense against unauthorized access.

- **Complexity & Length:** All work-related passwords must be a minimum of 16 characters. We highly recommend using "passphrases" (e.g., *blue-coffee-sunrise-retail*).
- **Protection:** Passwords must never be shared, written on sticky notes near POS terminals, or reused across different personal and corporate accounts.
- **Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** MFA is mandatory for all access to cloud systems, email, and financial tools. Disabling or bypassing MFA is strictly prohibited.

4. Prohibited Activities

Under no circumstances are users permitted to engage in the following activities while using Northside Home Goods systems or networks:

- **Bypassing Security:** Attempting to circumvent security controls, access unauthorized data, or use tools designed to crack passwords or intercept network traffic.
- **Unauthorized Software:** Installing personal software, unapproved browser extensions, or freeware on retail endpoints or corporate laptops without IT approval.
- **Inappropriate Content:** Accessing, storing, or transmitting pornographic, hateful, discriminatory, or otherwise illicit material.
- **Data Mishandling:** Forwarding internal business communications, customer lists, or payment card information to personal email accounts or unauthorized third-party cloud storage.
- **Shared Accounts:** Logging into a POS terminal or cloud application using another employee's credentials or an unauthorized generic "admin" account.

5. Email and Communications

- Corporate email is provided for business purposes. Users must not use corporate email to register for non-business-related services, promotions, or personal social media accounts.
- Users must remain vigilant against phishing. Any suspicious emails requesting invoice changes, wire transfers, or immediate password resets must be reported to IT immediately.

6. Policy Sanctions and Enforcement

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. Non-compliance may result in disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment or contractual obligations. In cases involving illegal activities, Northside Home Goods will cooperate fully with law enforcement authorities.